Such a possibility is not as far-fetched as it may seem after all, Bihar once did attract students from far and wide.

There are at least three major developments that I foresee in the 21st century. First, the Great Indian Migration Wave will veer southwards as high north–south wage differentials outweigh previous linguistic barriers. Since south India will also age faster than north India, it will precipitate the migration of a large number of people to work in the care economy, similar to migrations taking place towards Europe. Southward migration can potentially generate strong anti-migrant sentiments and nativist movements. The Bhojpuri-speaking belt will continue to send out migrants, as it has for centuries, and in many other regions there will be a transition from seasonal to semi-permanent, and then to permanent migrations. Autonomous female migration will also increase significantly due to better education and there will be concerns about internal brain drains, similar to the concern over the international brain drain from India in the 1960s and 70s.

In addition, there is a real risk of climate change and erratic weather triggering mass migrations in old and new corridors. Since Bangladesh is a low-lying area that is highly prone to the downside of climate change, it will lead to more migration to India, causing even more consternation than what is observed today. India will have to be prepared to deal with climate-change-induced internal and international migration.

Finally, as India’s economy grows, it will also become a country of immigration, attracting people in large numbers beyond Bangladesh and Nepal. The stock of migrant workers from North America and Europe, also called expatriates, can potentially increase from thousands to hundreds of thousands, giving a very different texture to India’s leading metropolitan centres.

As a matter of principle, India should embrace the tide of rising mobility that would add to its diversity. The leading personalities of Indian history were almost always migrants, who spent over half their life outside their place of birth, exposed to new and different ideas precisely because they moved.[57] As a migrant, the least one should be able to do is respect the cultures and sensibilities of the society one enters, maybe even learn the